

Word Count: 1100/1100

What is most important to you and why? (817)

To pursue a dignified calling.

In 2008 I rode a bicycle from Texas to Alaska. The goal was simple: to honor heroes like Steve. Steve had been diagnosed with stage IV pancreatic cancer when his daughter was three. I met him nine years later on the day he learned he was cancer--free. He lived, he told me, to see his daughter later graduate high school. Each day held a new hero and a new story. These stories inspired my team, and our story inspired them. Whether hills, rain, or constant fatigue, this motivational feedback loop never failed me. This was good work. Their struggle for life was dignified; honoring this struggle was dignified too.

Fast forward two years, and I'm in a boardroom discussing model inputs to project the European market value of a product that dominates the US market. I am recently graduated and the envy of my peers for having landed a prestigious job with a clear trajectory. The product is a last-resort cancer therapeutic for multiple myeloma. While we have a handle on the size of the patient population, we are uncertain as to how long patients remain on treatment, which drives dosage and determines market size.

"We know how fast they are dying here," the VP said, with an uncomfortable, maybe devious grin. He went on to enumerate his approach, which was smart. The room agreed. I didn't disagree. The collective struggles of people like Steve could point to profit potential. But it became clearer and clearer to me the heroism of those struggles was not present in this room. Their suffering was instead a difficult means to an ultimate end: growth.

I remember falling apart in a confidant's office. How could I invest myself in this project when I couldn't discern the clear, human principles guiding our behavior? I am not a martyr, and I knew a client's values would not always mirror my own. But I realized I couldn't thrive unless I believed that the dignity of others was at the center of my work. I did not care about growth *per se*. I left my prize job on my own terms.

I was lost. On a self-reflective walk around the Financial District, I met John on a tricycle rickshaw or "pedicab". I asked him: "Do you love your job?" He replied "yes" with a monkish calm. I decided to get back in a saddle, where I had once found dignified work. I embraced the simple, challenging, semi-spiritual work. In time, I fell in love with a unique community of pedicabbers. I even saw real business potential.

I founded Cabrio Taxi as San Francisco's premier pedicab company. My goal was to promote the dignity of the pedicabber. Many pedicabbers were uninspired or downright mistreated by their leasors. I knew a skilled pedicabber could earn a decent living, and the job was a blast. Many were college graduates with impressive cultural capital. If I could inspire pedicabbers to see themselves as client-centric professionals, I could build not only a healthy equipment rental business but also a unique advertising platform.

Beyond the usual small-business "drinking from a firehose," I found myself examining the principles governing my own behavior. During one advertising program, while nervous over sluggish sales, I paid my pedicabbers a smaller-than-normal fraction of their billing rate. My Director of Sales, a close ally and potential partner, became intensely uncomfortable. He felt I had prioritized profit over human worth -- he felt like I did in that boardroom. I learned then that dignifying work is a process which emerges, more than in any one project, in the long arc of a man.

My ability to build trust, to weave a story, to inspire a team moved us forward. We became the largest pedicab company in San Francisco. The pedicabbers thrived and took pride in their work. They felt “a part of something;” this was “the most beautiful community [he] had ever been apart of.” In our 3+ year, 80+ review history across multiple platforms, not one operator received a below-perfect rating. Meanwhile, everyone from John Stossel to the NY Post vilified pedicabs as “scams” in other major US cities. Our many eventual advertising clients trumpeted us as “amazing” and “great partners.” Levi’s, perhaps our City’s proudest brand, hired us directly to provide free pedicab rides at the 2012 World Series games; they’ve hired us for major pedicab campaigns four times since. Our products became common use for major events from Dreamforce to Outside Lands.

I built a successful, defensible company that holds human worth at the center of what it does. I am energized to have created a stable platform of value and worth for all who my company serves. Moreover I believe my focus on human worth is not an obstacle but instead the reason for my success.

What a man can do, he must do. Thus I pursue a dignified calling.

Why Stanford? (283)

I believe building companies that emphasize human worth is imperative. More than ever, we are looking for meaning in our work, our purchases, and our investments. We crave companies that can go beyond the functional requirements of business; we want companies to fulfill our higher human aspirations.

I want to build great companies: companies that are born of human principles; companies that galvanize employees, inspire customers, invigorate investors; companies that deliver on relevant, human-centric visions, and thereby make the world a better, more interesting place.

I believe any professed “professional” will seek structured learning. I cannot emulate ---- on my own or in any other MBA program ---- the culture and the resources of the GSB. The GSB creates true titans ---- not just of business but of the steady road of human progress. Chip Conley, James Curleigh, Phil Knight-- these are the people I want to surround myself with, learn from, and start companies with.

After I join the GSB community, I might join an early stage company like BloomBoard to deliver on their vision while staying focused on “core principles”. Or I might start earlier, from the ground up -- like a GSB Class of 2015 candidate I met, who with a fellow student is hatching “Uber for long-haul shipping.” In lockstep with my peers, I would obsess over a strategy, vision, mission, and culture to rally behind.

Then, if after many years I truly understand my pursuit, I wish to someday employ my world-renown degree to help others pursue their own callings in the realm of education.

I have learned by building a living, breathing company. I am now ready for an MBA program that highlights owning one’s actions, striving for something great, and respecting others. I am ready for the GSB.